

Dealing With Danni

After the announcer rattled through the standard background stuff, the introductions began.

"Introducing first... she is the number one ranked welterweight fighter in the league and a multi-time divisional and tournament champion... fighting out of the red corner... the team leader of *Rampage Sports, Incorporated*... from Pelican Falls, Louisiana... she is... DA-neeeeeeeel HAR-riiiiiis!

Choosing Danni's entrance song was an even bigger issue than Emma's because she had no productive thoughts on the matter. In fact, she seemed dismissive of the whole concept. Like having a song would be making too much of a fuss.

The others got involved and tried to inspire her. All suggestions were rejected. Soon enough, her teammates got fed up and the decision was taken out of her hands.

The process was complicated. The women felt a certain responsibility to get this one right, and capturing Danni's personality is not an easy thing. Many excellent choices were considered and dismissed. To the point where I was starting to worry we'd have to commission a brand new song just for the purpose... which would, in fact, defeat the purpose.

Eventually a consensus was reached, and *Sorry Not Sorry* by RSI's own Demi Lovato was selected.

As with Emma, the content of the song applies in no way whatsoever. But surprisingly enough, no one had to explain the decision to me because I got it right away. Just say the title out loud, and you realize it's Danni to a tee. As in, she's sorry she kicked your ass, but not really because that's her job. And it really isn't her fault she's so much better than you. That's just the way it is.

Danneel Harris... the apologetic conqueror.

Naturally, Danni fought the selection... and she can be quite the immovable object when she wants to be. But she stood no chance against the combined resolve of the women of Rampage Sports.

The song spun up at the bridge as Danni emerged from the tunnel, with Steph, Mandy and Marcy right behind her.

Now payback is a bad bitch, and baby I'm the baddest...

She looked good to me. Maybe I had made a difference. Maybe Steph had said something sage and comforting. Or maybe Danni was distracted from her concerns by the sizable roar she got from the crowd. Her devoted fans, letting her know they were behind her. She acknowledged them a bit on the way in, but mostly kept her eyes focused on the cage. An approach that was part professionalism and part humility. Though she takes the same *business first* attitude as Emily, she also doesn't really understand all that her fans see in her. I've resigned myself to the fact that she's never going to.

"And her opponent... also a multi-time tournament champion and the current divisional title holder... fighting out of the blue corner... the team leader of *Savage Wolf MMA*... from Tyneside, England... she is... CHER-yl Cooooooooooooole!"

The pop the crowd gave Cheryl seemed noticeably less than Danni's... though I freely admit my opinion is biased. Regardless, Cole had plenty of fans, and they let her hear it. Though her entrance was more animated, she also seemed zeroed in on the goal.

Danni didn't ignore her, but she paid her no particular mind, either. She was busy talking last-minute strategy with Steph while she loosened up.

"She's all business," Dragon commented.

"She always is," Sophia and I said in unison.

With the intros finished, the referee - a role once again filled by Natasha Yi - brought the fighters to the center for final instructions. It was tense, but no more so than usual. I think Cole's hard look was meant to be intimidating, but it was wasted on Danni. Her plain expression was the perfect response because it was effortless. She wasn't trying to look bored with Cole's antics. She just was.

Yi finished her spiel, sent the fighters to their opposite corners, then motioned for the bell.

That moment had arrived again. That time when all the training and talking and build up stopped, and the only test that mattered began.

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The first few exchanges yielded little to talk about. Just a few probing attacks, with no significant damage done. The only thing worth noting was that Danni looked totally focused and in control. Her earlier misgivings hidden away in some emotional drawer. Not a small accomplishment, considering all she had riding on this.

Cheryl upped the pressure a bit. A quick jab, cross combo was followed by a left hook that would definitely have left a mark if it landed. But, while Danni's game was solid all-around, defense was still her strong suit... and she showed once again why she was brilliant at it. Instead of just blocking the hook she turned her body into it. Taking the punch harmlessly on her shoulder, while keeping her hands up and ready to attack. She was now in prime position to exploit Cole's miss. She already had her left handed cocked, ready to unload.

The problem? No Cheryl.

Cole had pulled the hook a bit, then gone low with what I had to admit was a pretty good takedown move. Coiling like a spring, she suddenly shot forward. Her shoulder slammed into Danni right around hip height and she moved to latch her arms around Danni's legs.

There was no earthly reason for Danni to expect a takedown from the strike-happy Cole. She hadn't attempted even one in their previous fights. I was fairly sure she hadn't attempted one throughout her run in this tournament. In fact, I was willing to bet she'd never attempted one. Ever. Which put the element of surprise squarely in her favor.

It also put a cold shiver down my spine. Cole had put together an impressive career by focusing on the things she does best, and she'd be the first to tell you so. So why try something now that she'd never done before? The most obvious answer was that she was looking to exploit some weakness she'd found in Danni's game.

One glance at Sophia told me I was not alone in this concern.

Cole surged forward and drove her shoulder into Danni's body. Running the shot, just as Fox had done. Only... not really.

First off - while Cole's move was good, she was no Megan Fox. Her technique didn't have the same speed, and certainly not the same crispness. On top of that, I suspected Danni had learned some hard lessons after being put through the wringer by Fox. So, despite the fact that she never could have predicted a move like this from Cheryl, she reacted to it beautifully. Immediately recognizing what was coming, she got her left leg back - improving her base to weather the attack. More importantly, she got the leg out of reach and denied Cole the wrap up she needed. What followed looked more like an outtake from a slapstick comedy than something that belonged in an MMA cage. Cole pushed and pushed, but Danni kept her balance by latching on to her opponent's body and simply going with the flow - literally hopping on her free leg as Cheryl plowed her along. It looked every bit as ridiculous as it sounds, but it kept Cole from getting the takedown she wanted. Trouble was, it also went on for much longer than it should have - the two of them tangled up and wobbling all around the cage. Almost as if Cheryl didn't recognize the futility of her efforts. Like she thought she just needed to push a little harder to get there.

She eventually caught on to the fact that it was never going to happen and slowed her momentum. That could have allowed Danni to try to improve her position and maybe even go for a choke - except Cole did something a little unorthodox. Keeping hold of her opponent's right leg, she lifted it high off the canvas. The move threw Danni completely off balance and Cole finally got that takedown after all... though, I don't really know why she bothered. Simply dumping Danni over accomplished little because she refused to give up her hold on Cheryl's body. The end result was that both fighters toppled to the canvas. Though Danni ended up on the bottom, the messy takedown allowed her to easily keep Cole from getting any sort of dominant position.

That didn't stop her from trying to dominate, though.

As soon as they landed, Cole tried to push her way up Danni's body... and I was quickly losing the thread as to what she could be up to. Every move seemed to make less and less sense. The element of surprise was gone. In fact, there'd been nothing surgical about what she'd done so far, at all. No sense that she had some stunning tactical insight she was trying to make use of. Her takedown attempt had started decently, then devolved into a disaster. A mundane attack that had been turned aside with ease. So, why stay with it? I couldn't say for sure, but I found myself wondering if it had been more of a generic plan. It's a widely

known fact that the canvas was a place most RSI fighters hated to be. We have some grinders like Tiz and Krystal Forscutt who are willing to go with the flow and scrap it out wherever the fight goes, but most of our fighters prefer to stay on their feet. Maybe Cole wanted Danni in a place she would be less comfortable?

If that's what Cheryl was thinking then she'd picked the wrong *Rampager* because Danni is the exception to the rule. She's always been a decent ground fighter, and she'd exponential improvement in the showdown with Fox. Did Cole really think she could do better than one of the most feared submission experts in the league?

It certainly seemed like she was going to try.

Danni read her opponent's move as any fighter would... that Cheryl was trying to get to mount position. The holy grail of ground fighting. If your opponent is able to gain full mount on you, you'd better hope the round is almost over because the danger is immense, escape is nearly impossible and you're not going to last long.

Knowing this, Danni scrambled to get her defense in place. Looking to catch Cole in what's called the guard position. Though very different from the 'guard' we talk about when striking, it's purpose is basically the same. It's how you defend yourself. The goal is to wrap your opponent with your legs. To control her and keep her from getting to you.

Danni was fast and technically perfect. Pushing and grappling to make room to get her legs up almost instantly. If Cole had seen an opening that would let her get to mount, Danni had slammed it shut and barred the door.

Trouble was, Cole wasn't trying to get to mount.

With impressive quickness, Cheryl ducked under and brushed Danni's upstretched legs aside as she moved up the RSI team leader's right side.

The warning light snapped on in my head.

Side control!

Not as bad as mount, but not good either. If Cole got solid position, she would have an array of options at her disposal. Arm bar. Elbow strikes. Hell, if she really got in deep, she could literally crush Danni into the mat.

Luckily Danni's warning light was better than mine because she was moving before the thought fully registered in my head.

As Cole moved in, Danni rolled up on her right side. At the same time, she spread her left leg out a bit and brought her right knee up. Her arms folded in to her center with her elbows tucked in tight. She pressed her palms together like she was praying then tucked them beside her head like she was going to sleep.

Just like that, she'd expertly created a protective cage around herself.

By rolling up, she had avoided being caught flat on her back. Spreading the left leg out had given her an anchor to prevent Cole from pushing her around or trying to roll her, and bringing her knee up had invaded some of the space Cole wanted to occupy. Arms and elbows in would keep Cheryl from crushing down on her torso. Also, having the arms in and her hands together made it very difficult for Cole to go after the armbar, and the *sleeping* position kept Cheryl away from her neck.

In a grappling match, Cole probably would've be out of luck at that point. But here in the MMA cage, she still had some options. Punches and elbow strikes were still on the menu, and Cheryl gave it a go. But Danni didn't just lie there and hope she didn't get beat up. She was actively countering and trying to improve her situation. When Cole started with the elbows, Danni pulled her head down behind her hands and started to squirm away. Cole tried another elbow. Block. Squirm. They did it once more before Cole realized her prey was slowly escaping. She quit the elbows and focused on getting back in position. Meanwhile, Danni got her defensive cage back in place. Net result? They were right back where they started.

After a little pushing and pulling as they grappled for position, Cole tried the elbows again. Danni patiently defended and worked on her escape. Again Cole was forced to give it up, and they went right back to start.

After another cycle got them nowhere, Yi warned Cheryl that she needed to see some significant action or she was going to step in.

Cole went for broke. Showing her quickness again, she suddenly spun to reposition herself above Danni's head. The *north-south* position. The same spot Fox had taken before going for that fight-ending choke. No doubt that's what Cole was after, but Danni was having none of it. Cole had to give up a little control to make the move, and Danni squirmed free instantly. Like she knew what was coming and had been waiting for it. Cole moved to go after her, but Danni was up on her knees and facing her opponent in the blink of an eye. Seeing how ready the taller brunette was, Cole wisely backed off and both fighters climbed to their feet.

I breathed a sigh of relief and unclenched my fists without realizing I had balled them up in the first place. Not that my angst wasn't well-founded. Ground fighting is a very intense thing... mostly because of how suddenly it can change. In the stand up game, you make a mistake and your opponent will likely make you pay. Certainly not a good thing - and if you make too many, your night will be over fast - but it would be very unlucky for a single miscue to cost you the fight. On the ground though... the slightest error could lead to all kinds of trouble. Sometimes it results in a sudden submission. More often it lets your opponent catch you in a terrible, unrecoverable position. Then comes the slow yet relentless march toward death as she patiently maneuvers you toward the finish. Either way, you're likely to end up screaming your surrender before too long. So, despite the fact that Danni had never been in any real trouble, I knew she had been inches from it the entire time.

Even now, I remained uneasy. Whatever secret Cole had hoped to exploit, Danni had denied her. But was it that simple? Maybe something Cheryl had seen in older footage? A flaw that was no longer a flaw because

it was uncovered and corrected through the endless hours of sparring Danni's teammates had put her through?

Possible, but unlikely. If something like that had been discovered, Steph would have been aware of it.

That left a very unappealing alternative. That Danni had just been lucky with her defense, and the flaw remained. Which meant Cole was certain to go after it again.

The good news was that all that grappling had eaten nearly three minutes of the round, leaving slightly more than two to go. I really wanted Danni to be able to stop and get Steph's thoughts on the matter. The sooner, the better.

As the action resumed, it quickly became apparent that strangeness was going to be the theme of the fight. I mentioned earlier that the common thread binding all of Savage Wolf's fighters is strategy. Namely, *attack, attack, attack!* But now, Cole was hanging back. Pawing here and there, but making no real effort to go after her opponent.

This quickly became a problem for the defensive-minded Danni. Not that she couldn't generate her own offense, but doing so was not really in the game plan tonight. With Cole normally preferring the hell-or-high-water approach, fights between them were a contest of strengths, and the basic question was always the same: could Cole overwhelm Danni with her relentless attacks, or would Harris kill her with defense and counters?

Only now, Cheryl wasn't doing her part. That left Danni confused, and you could see it in her tentative movements. Her instinct said move forward. To force her opponent to engage. But this was Cheryl Cole, and the strategy for handling her said keep your guard up and prepare for an all-out assault.

For a while, they just circled and jabbed and... nothing. It was more like dancing than fighting. After a while, Yi got involved again and warned both fighters that they needed to engage. Which was ridiculous. When was the last time anyone ever had to tell Cheryl Cole to start throwing punches?

A little more time went by until Danni finally made the move to pick up the slack. Advancing behind her jab, she pushed Cole toward the fence. She was still cautious and non-committal. Fully aware that this wasn't the way it was supposed to be and that Cole could start unloading at any time. The lack of certainty gave Cheryl plenty of time to maneuver, and she easily circled out before Danni could cut her off.

Danni stalked after her, but Cole seemed content to keep her distance. Twice more it appeared Yi would step in. Each time, Cole suddenly surged forward with a flurry of activity. Quick, short strikes thrown in bunches. Danni defended them easily, but Cole retreated before a counter-assault could be launched.

That was the story for most of what remained of the round. But then - with less than forty seconds to go - Cole went on the attack.

Jab, cross.

Danni defended both perfectly and responded with a jab of her own to back Cole off, but the British fighter guarded and kept coming.

Hook, straight left.

A changeup combo, designed to confound expectations. No problem for Danni, who was one of the best at simply dealing with what was in front of her and not getting caught up in trying to predict her opponent. But Cole's sudden aggressiveness was like a breath of fresh air. Finally, here was the Cheryl we all knew.

Danni padded out her jab to put some space between them. Cole responded with her own jab, then took a big, long step to eat up that space. She was coming in low, trying to get under Danni's guard. I had visions of a lunging punch to the midsection. Danni saw it the same way and calmly lowered her guard to protect her abdominal area. Then Cole went even lower and drove right through her.

Another god-damn takedown. This one perfectly executed and beautifully disguised. By all accounts, it should have worked.

But Danni somehow picked up on what was coming at the last second. She got her hands up and got hold of Cole's body. Cole got the takedown and they both went down together again - Cole on top with Danni on the bottom. But, as before, Danni's quick reaction had prevented Cheryl from getting good position. Cole scrambled, but Danni got her legs up and again denied her the mount. Cole slid left and settled for side control. Danni read it and got that defensive cage around herself again. And then... nothing.

For the final twenty seconds or so, not a damn thing happened. The women squirmed and grappled a bit, but Cole made no real effort to do anything and Danni had no trouble staying out of danger.

Yi seemed to be thinking about standing them up when the clapper sounded to signal the final ten seconds of the round. There was no point in getting involved then, so she stood by and waited for the bell to sound.

I was just as relieved as I was confused. What the hell was Cole doing? She wasn't fighting anything like herself, and what she was doing didn't look very organized. All this prancing and pawing and grappling had gotten her nowhere. And what was with that final sequence? Though Danni's defense had lowered the odds, Cheryl still had opportunities there. Why not take a shot? Why was she so content to just ride out the round?

If there were answers to be had, I knew Steph would have them.

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I was too lost in thought to notice no one in the box said anything during the break. My guess was that Sophia was similarly preoccupied. Both of us pleased that Danni had not only survived the round but had done exceptionally well given Cole's strange tactics. Both also concerned about what those tactics meant.

In the cage, things in the RSI corner were unremarkable. No real damage had been done, so Marcy focused on Danni's muscles - looking to keep her loose and limber - while Steph dove into the strategy. There was

no sign they were as concerned as I was. No urgency or frustration showing between them. Though I'm sure they weren't pleased with how the round had gone, they weren't really displeased, either. Cole had come out with a surprising gameplan, but Danni hadn't let it rattle her. She had stayed patient and safe, and now we were pretty much back at square one... except Cole had now shown her cards. That gave RSI's two greatest strategic minds something to work with, and it looked to me like they had a pretty good idea of what they wanted to do.

How much of that was true, and how much was just what I wanted to believe? I had no idea.

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The second round opened with more circling and pawing. Cole still showed no interest in slugging with her opponent, while Danni stayed alert for a typical, all-out, Cheryl-style assault. But once she felt certain Cheryl was going to continue to lay back, she started to take the initiative.

It was a predictable plan... mostly because it was something that had to be done. Being defensive was one thing, but giving Cole all day to plot her next move was a recipe for disaster. So Danni applied some pressure in a careful but steady manner. Using movement and a steady jab to cut off the ring and herd Cole into places where she was forced to engage. It worked, but only at the most basic level. Because Cole had a jab of her own, which she used to ward Danni off and make her escape each time.

That dance went on long enough that you could feel it starting to wear on the crowd's collective patience. This was not what they were here for, and they were starting to grumble a little about it.

There wasn't much that Yi could do, either. Punches were being thrown. Exchanges were happening. It wasn't her fault that they were terrible.

Nearly a full minute went by. Cole showed zero initiative. Which left it all up to Danni.

The next exchange saw her try to force the issue with a bigger combination... and Cole responded with a bigger counter. Danni jabbed, then followed with the right hand. Cole slipped inside of it, landed a quick jab, then threw her own right hand. Danni slipped that, then countered with a solid body shot. The crowd grew excited. Finally... the kind of back and forth they expected.

Then Cole backed away.

Still, the ice had been broken, giving the masses hope that the battle was heating up. Cole still seemed unwilling to come forward, so Danni tried again. The result was the same. A quick, intense exchange that ended when Cole backed out.

There was not much Danni could do about the problem. She could use her movement to corner Cheryl and get the action started, but you can't just stand there once the fists start flying. You have to slip and step and move. In the process, positions change... which is how Cole was finding the room she needed to retreat.

The crowd grew more impatient... but it was Danni's impatience that really caught my attention.

The next time she got Cole where she wanted her, she was more insistent about keeping her there. To do that, she broke the rule I just mentioned. She kinda just stood there. Instead of going with her natural movement, she put a premium on maintaining her position. She came straight ahead, and poured on the pressure. For a brief moment, it seemed to work. Cole tried the jab to move Danni around and make her way out, but she got a little flustered when Danni just kept coming.

Then Cheryl went back to being Cheryl.

First came the left hook. Then a pair of hooks to the body. And finally a right uppercut that was meant to kill.

The combo was fast, strong and on target. Vintage Cheryl Cole. Exactly the kind of thing Danni had come prepared to deal with.

Only now she had left her gameplan, and she was standing flat-footed right in front of her opponent. She managed to get inside the hook, but both body blows landed perfectly. Then came the uppercut. Danni slid right and leaned that way, too. Doing everything she could to get out of the way.

The punch missed by the thinnest of margins. So close that I swear Cole's glove wiped the sweat off of Danni's cheek.

Disaster averted but danger still remained. Danni's frantic dodge had flipped their positions, and Cole got both hands into her and jammed her hard against the fence. A bad situation that Danni was well-trained to handle. First step, raise your shields. Cole was going to be coming in swinging, so Danni put her guard up and got ready for it. Then she took a peek, and found Cheryl wasn't throwing. Weird, but no matter... on to step two. Get control of the situation. Find your opponent's hands and try to get a grip on them. That part got a little tricky. First of all, Cole expected the move, and actively tried to stay out of Danni's grasp. In fact, she seemed intent on getting hold of Danni's hands, instead. The result was a lot of darting hand motions as they chased after each other's wrists. While that was going on, Cheryl ploughed straight into Danni like a freight train. Going body on body and crushing her against the mesh. It didn't look very comfortable, but Danni stayed the course. Battling to keep her hands free and not let Cole get any free shots at her.

A long period of grappling and shoving followed. Cole was leaning so hard on Danni that I thought the fence might give out. Meanwhile, Danni kept twisting and violently wrenching her hands free. Making sure she had the tools she needed to defend herself when the limbs started to fly.

Seconds ticked by. The intricate battle continued. Danni was in a bad spot, but she was doing a great job of defending and preventing it from getting worse. Cole hadn't even gotten a punch off, so far. She seemed so intent on smushing Danni that I didn't see how she'd find the room throw one, anyway.

More time went by. Nearly a full thirty seconds had passed since Cole pinned Danni down, but she hadn't been able to make anything of it.

Finally, the action slowed as Danni managed to get a firm grip on both of Cole's hands. Cole kept pushing and shoving, but - try as she might - she wasn't able to force Danni through the mesh.

Eventually, Yi was forced to step in and move the fight back to center. All that grinding seemed to put a little wear on each of the battlers, but both still looked ready and willing.

Two minutes to go as the action restarted. Again with the circling. A few light exchanges came to nothing. Finally, Danni tried to press a little harder. Cole jabbed her off and dove in low... and down to the canvas they both went again. No real advantage for anybody. Just a tangle of bodies and limbs spilling to the mat.

This was getting ridiculous.

Cole pushed her way on top, but her position gave her no leverage. She dug a little at Danni's arms, but wasn't able to pull one free. She tried a few punches, but Danni covered up well. There was a lot of squirming and twisting going on... and it all started to look more like a catfight than a professional MMA bout. Danni was slithering around the mat as she tried to get out from under, while Cole seemed totally committed to making sure that didn't happen - to the exclusion of all else.

With twenty seconds to go, Yi stood them back up. Cole circled out of range. With so little time left, Danni couldn't even be bothered to chase her. There was another brief skirmish with about eight seconds left, then nothing more until the bell sounded.

I no longer had any idea what Cole's game was... and I was getting a little pissed off about it.

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The round break played out much the same as the first one had. All was strangely quiet up where I was, though I was once again too preoccupied to notice. In the cage... well, there still wasn't much for Marcy to do. For all the pushing and shoving and grinding, this fight had produced nothing in the way of damage or injury. It was a fact I could not comprehend. Not with these two fighters in the cage.

Steph and Danni still seemed calm... which was another thing I could make no sense of. Cole's strategy was so odd... how could it not be concerning them? Did they understand it better than I did? Had Steph come up with some way to counter it? Maybe. Danni had done a much better job of holding Cole off in the second frame. Maybe something Steph had said was the key to that. But it still wasn't getting the job done.

As for me... I thought I had been pretty well-behaved up to this point. In deference to those around me, I had not yelled or carried on or said any of those words I had been planning back at the start. But with the rounds ticking by and the frightening mystery of Cole's intent still hanging over everything, my natural lack of patience started to show.

"What the fuck is going on here?" I said aloud as I bounced out of my chair and walked back for another bottle of water - solely because I needed to get up.

"I don't know," Sophia said. "I really don't know."

She sounded just as worried and frustrated as I was.

"Cole has to be after something," she continued.

"But WHAT? She's had two rounds, and she's gotten nowhere. If she's found some weakness, why hasn't she exploited it?"

I was shouting a little, but Sophia didn't seem to take it personally.

"Maybe she's not good enough," she said. "Maybe it's something she doesn't really have the skills to go after."

I gravitated back toward the chair, suddenly very interested in her theory. I liked it a lot - probably because it offered an explanation that didn't mean Danni was in deep trouble - but I still had questions.

"If she can't do it, then why does she keep trying?"

Sophia had no answer.

I turned back toward the cage as the seconds were clearing out. I started to sell myself on Sophia's idea.

Could it be that simple? Probably not, but... maybe. Yeah, maybe. It made some sense, right?

I started to buy in... mostly because I wanted to. After all, it was just as possible as anything else. And it allowed me to breathe a little more freely, which was always a good thing.

Then Dragon leaned forward and said, "I know I don't know anything, but I feel compelled to point out that Ms. Cole is winning this fight."

Sophia and I turned on him simultaneously.

"What the fuck are you talking about?" she snarled.

"Not a god damn thing she's done has worked," I said.

"OK, woah..." Dragon said as he instinctively recoiled out of reach. "First of all, I already said I don't know anything. So let's not overreact. I'm simply telling you what I'm seeing."

"But how are you seeing it that way?" I said. "Are you watching a different fight?"

"No, I'm watching this fight," he said. "You say nothing Cheryl has done has worked. I'm inclined to agree. But the thing is, she's the only one doing anything at all."

I started to snap back, then stopped abruptly. Sophia said nothing. We both turned and looked down at the cage.

Dragon continued to make his point.

"I admit that the fight has been pretty boring, and that Cole has accomplished little. But she appears to be the only one trying. She nearly ended the fight in one punch a few minutes ago. Yes, she missed... but that was the only memorable moment of the entire round. Meanwhile, Danneel hasn't done anything but fight her off. So, when it comes down to it, Cheryl is winning."

Neither Sophia nor I even looked at him. We just stared at the cage as we suddenly realized what Cole's strategy was.

When Sophia spoke again, the words all but slithered out from between her teeth.

"That... fucking..."

"...bitch," I finished for her.